The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump warned that **Iran** could be “taken out in one night” and “that night might be tomorrow”. He has set a deadline of 8pm Eastern Time on Tuesday for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. The president said his administration has a plan to “decimate” every bridge and power plant in Iran if no agreement is reached. Talks co-ordinated by Pakistan and other countries are continuing.

Iran’s top military commander said Mr Trump’s comments were “delusional”. Earlier the regime rejected an American ceasefire proposal, reportedly insisting instead on a permanent end to the war. Meanwhile Israel attacked Tehran, Iran’s capital, hitting aircraft and infrastructure at several airports, including Mehrabad, the city’s main domestic airport. Separate strikes shut petrochemical plants in the city of Asaluyeh and damaged parts of the South Pars gas complex.

Four astronauts aboard NASA’s **Artemis II mission** witnessed a total solar eclipse and lost contact with Earth for about 40 minutes as they passed behind the Moon. Earlier they broke a record set by the crew of Apollo 13 in 1970, travelling a greater distance from Earth than any humans had before. The astronauts also spoke to Mr Trump, who invited them to the White House.

Private-sector growth in the **euro zone** slowed in March. The composite purchasing managers' index, a measure that combines surveys of manufacturing and service industries, fell from 51.9 in February to 50.7 in March, its worst performance in nine months. Businesses have been hit by soaring energy prices because of the war in Iran.

Pershing Square Capital, a hedge fund, offered to buy **Universal Music Group** in a deal which values the world's largest music label at $64bn. Universal's shares, which had fallen by over 30% in the past six months over worries that AI-generated music could saturate the music industry and reduce profits, jumped by over 10% in early trading. The deal is expected to be completed by the end of the year.

LG **Energy Solution**, a South Korean battery-maker, reported a worse than expected operating loss of over 200bn won ($138m) in the first quarter of 2026. Waning demand for electric vehicles dragged down revenue by 2.5% compared to the year before. The company's shares fell by 1% on the announcement. It is increasingly focusing on making batteries for power grids and data centres.

Vietnam's lawmakers unanimously elected **To Lam**, the leader of the country's Communist Party, as state president. The appointment is unprecedented for Vietnam, where, unlike in China, leadership of the state and the party have been separate. The centralisation of power will help Mr Lam carry out economic reforms, though it has raised fears of increased authoritarianism.

Figure of the day: 17%, the percentage of Americans who bet on a sporting event last year, more than double the rate two years earlier. Read the full story.

Photograph: AP

Trump threatens war crimes in Iran

Donald Trump has vowed to bomb Iran hard enough to send it “back to the Stone Ages”. On Saturday he gave Iran a 48-hour deadline to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, an ultimatum Iran has so far dismissed. A day later America’s president announced his next targets: “Tuesday will be Power Plant Day, and Bridge Day, all wrapped up in one.”

Such attacks could amount to serious war crimes. Power plants and other civilian infrastructure are generally protected under the laws of war. These sites can lose that protection if they are used for military purposes, but only if their destruction provides a “military advantage” that outweighs civilian harm; America’s armed forces usually determine the legality of any strikes on a case-by-case basis. Mr Trump’s suggestion that “each and every one” of Iran’s power plants be hit “simultaneously” would cause considerable suffering among the country’s 93m people. By any reading of the laws of war, that is the definition of an indiscriminate attack.

Photograph: Reuters

A MAGA pilgrimage to Budapest

J.D. Vance, America's vice-president, arrived in Budapest on Tuesday to show his support for Viktor Orban, Hungary's prime minister, ahead of parliamentary elections on April 12th. Most opinion polls show Mr Orban's party, Fidesz, well behind its upstart challenger, Tisza, led by a former Fidesz man, Peter Magyar.

Mr Orban has fostered close ties with leading figures on the American right ever since his party won election in 2010. His government financed the Danube Institute, a conservative think-tank, to export its hard-right politics around the world. For MAGA Republicans Mr Orban is a model to emulate: a scourge of the woke, a defender of borders, tradition and Christianity. Mr Vance's visit has been cast by Mr Orban's government as a celebration of the two countries' ideological ties. Yet Mr Orban might have hoped that Donald Trump would have come instead. Notwithstanding the polls, there is much uncertainty ahead of the election. But America's president is known to stay away from losers.

Photograph: Reuters

Taiwan’s opposition leader visits China

On Tuesday the leader of Taiwan’s main opposition party, Cheng Li-wun, travelled to China at the invitation of President Xi Jinping—the first such trip in a decade. The Kuomintang (KMT) and the Chinese Communist Party were once sworn enemies. Now China sees the KMT as its best chance of peacefully reuniting the island with the mainland. Ms Cheng has frequently asserted that both sides of the Taiwan Strait are part of “one China”.

If Ms Cheng were to make similar comments during a formal visit to the mainland it would be a coup for China’s propaganda machine. Ms Cheng’s movements are being closely watched in America, too, where a bipartisan group of senators has been urging Taiwan’s parties to unite behind a proposed $40bn increase in defence spending, which Ms Cheng is blocking. But in roughly a month there is a summit planned between Donald Trump and Mr Xi, at which China’s president is expected to press for reduced American arms sales to Taiwan.

Photograph: Getty Images

A bond market tug of war

Governments' borrowing costs have been in flux almost everywhere. In the turmoil of the Iran war bond yields first soared—reaching highs not seen in Britain since 2008 or Japan since 1997—before falling back last week.

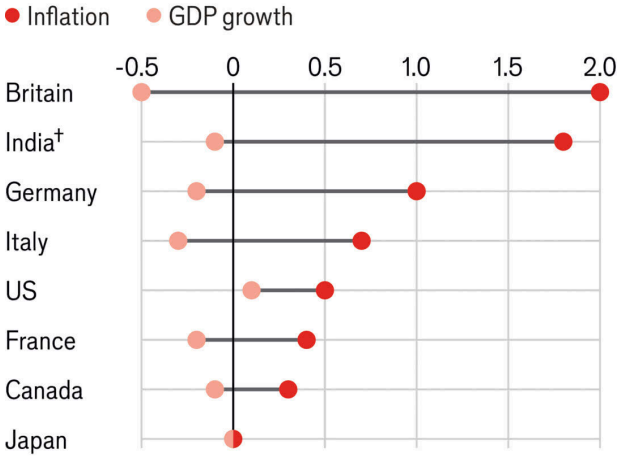
Optimists might conclude that yields have dropped because hostilities will soon end, allowing oil to flow freely through the Strait of Hormuz. But optimists generally do not pursue careers in bond investing. In the case of the Iran war, the job means fretting about stagflation: economic stagnation combined with high inflation. Borrowing costs are whipsawing because these two dangers tug them in opposite directions.

Governments most exposed to inflationary pressure from Hormuz's closure have seen their yields jump highest (Britain, India). Early in the war traders bet that the Federal Reserve would stop cutting rates to contain the inflationary effects of the energy shock. Now they expect cuts again to promote growth—something that could exacerbate inflation. The longer Hormuz stays shut the higher the stakes get.

Fire and ice

Cumulative change in 2026 and 2027 forecasts*

Percentage points



*Forecasts made in Mar 2026 compared with Dec 2025 †Fiscal years beginning April

Source: OECD

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily Quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Tuesday: Which political party won the largest share of the vote in the recent Baden-Wũrttemburg regional election?

Monday: Who is the president of the European Central Bank?

A business that makes nothing but money is a poor business.

Henry Ford